

Chapter 3

Purpose of Groups

Being clear about the purpose of the group is perhaps the most important group leadership concept to be learned. All the other skills and tasks discussed in this book—such as planning a group, holding and shifting the focus, and cutting off and drawing out members—are based on the leader's clear understanding of the purpose of the group. Because we consider this concept so important, we discuss clarity of purpose in this separate chapter and continue to mention it throughout the book. *Purpose* refers to why the group is meeting and what the goals and objectives are. (We sometimes use the terms *goals* and *objectives* in place of *purpose*.) When the leader fully understands the purpose of the group, it is easier for him to decide such things as its size, membership, session length, and number of sessions (Brown, 2009).

The purpose of the group serves as a map for the leader. Members and leaders must be clear about both the general purpose of the group and the specific purpose of each session (Hulse-Killacky, Killacky, & Donigian, 2001). Sometimes the purpose is obvious, such as losing weight, quitting smoking, overcoming a phobia, or learning study skills. Often, however, members' needs are not so specific. Leading groups of people with various needs means that the leader must help the group decide which needs are reasonable and possible to address. *Clarity of purpose helps the leader keep the members on course by suggesting relevant activities, asking relevant questions, and cutting off irrelevant discussions.*

When the Leader Is Unclear About the Purpose

As we said, groups are often confusing, boring, or unproductive when the objectives are not well-defined or the leader does not follow the stated objectives. The following are examples where the purpose is either unclear or is not adhered

to by the leader. We follow each example with a discussion of what the leader could have done to ensure clarity of purpose.

EXAMPLES

Purpose: Learning to survive the pain of divorce

It is the first meeting. Members have been talking about their loneliness, self-doubts, and fears. Alan interrupts abruptly and starts talking about his thoughts about changing jobs. The leader says to the group, "What are your thoughts on how Alan should go about making this career decision?" For the next 30 minutes, the group gives Alan suggestions on how to handle the situation, with much of the talk centering on what salary he should request.

This leader made a mistake by asking for comments on what Alan was saying. The stated purpose was support and therapy to survive the pain of divorce, so the leader should not have focused the group on Alan's concern about his career. Rather, the leader should have halted the discussion and redirected the group to a discussion of the members' feelings about their divorces.

Allowing the group to continue the career discussion probably resulted in some members becoming bored and frustrated. Members may also have become angry and left the group or cut in on the discussion and attacked Alan or the group. Such responses could have been prevented had the leader been clear about the purpose and then used her skills to redirect the group. For example, the leader could have said something like, "Alan, that's an important topic; however, it does not fit with the purpose of the group at this time. If you feel the need to talk about this, let's schedule an appointment or you may ask members after the session ends for their input."

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Purpose: Orientation to prison life

The group starts with the leader going over the procedures for meals, visits, and weekend passes. One man brings up the prison's policy of no passes for the first month. Another inmate chimes in about the lack of places to be alone when he has visitors. Another asks the group what they think of that situation. Different members offer their opinions and ideas about it. Following this, the leader brings the discussion back to the policies and procedures by discussing mealtime procedures. One inmate mentions that he is a vegetarian, and two others ask him a number of questions about why he doesn't eat meat. Another inmate says he thinks the meals are terrible. The leader asks what other members think about the meals. Two inmates then start complaining about the food, the heating in the rooms, and the lack of television sets on the units. The group ends with very little having been said about procedures in the prison.

Because this leader did not stick to the purpose and was more worried about whether people would talk, he let the group wander. There is a good chance that some members will be resistant at the second meeting because the first one was boring and irrelevant. The leader should have halted the discussion on the

side issues and brought the group back to its intended purpose by saying kindly but firmly, "The purpose of this group is to discuss the rules and procedures of the prison. I'd be more than happy to arrange a time to discuss these other matters. However, for now let's get back to the topic—let's talk about the procedures for having a visitor."

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Purpose: Adult Sunday school discussion group on church-related issues
It is the fourth session, and the topic scheduled for discussion this week is "Ways the Church Can Be More Responsive to the Changing Family—The Single-Parent Family and the Stepfamily." The discussion has been interesting and relevant. Then a member asks, "Why is the divorce rate so high now?" The leader mistakenly throws the question open to the group and, for the next 25 minutes, four of the nine members argue about the many reasons. When the group returns to the original topic of the church being responsive, the other members have lost interest and have little energy for the original topic.

Again, the leader's lack of clarity caused this group to go awry. If the leader had been clear about the purpose of this meeting, she would not have let the members discuss the causes of divorce. Rather, she would have said something like, "That might be something we could discuss after the meeting. However, let's stay with the topic for this week."

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Purpose: Dealing with fears of going to middle school next year
It is the second session and members are talking about their different fears. One student talked about her fear of changing classes. When the leader asks if others share the same fear, Tommy jumps in and starts to talk about how he is afraid of the dark sometimes. The leader asks members if they are afraid of the dark. Carlos says he is a little. The group then discusses fear of the dark for the rest of the session.

The leader allowed this group to deviate from the purpose of the group. If she had been clear on the purpose, she would not have focused on Tommy's concern because his concern had nothing to do with going to middle school next year.

In each of these examples, the leader does not stick to the purpose, which causes the group to be superficial. *Awareness of the purpose is very important for any group situation.*

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GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Clarity of Purpose

Go to the videos on Clarity of Purpose (3.1, 3.2, and 3.3) on the *Group Counseling Skills* videos to see how important clarity of purpose can be. Watch a discussion and three clarity of purpose demonstrations, one of a group leader without clarity of purpose, and two demonstrations of a group leader with clarity of purpose.

Determining the Purpose of the Group

When setting up a group, the leader must assess the potential members' needs and then decide which kind of group will be most helpful. For example, a leader working with a group of mentally challenged teenagers might decide on an education group covering such topics as sex, money, and job hunting or a counseling or support group to help them explore their feelings. Gathering information about the members' needs, deciding which needs can be met by the group, and then conceptualizing the kind of group that will ideally meet those needs clarifies the purpose for the leader. The next example illustrates the process of clarifying the purpose by determining the kind of group.

■ EXAMPLE

A therapist has been asked to lead a group for pregnant teenage girls. She gathers information about the members' ages, length of pregnancies, attitudes of their parents, and reasons for wanting to be in a group. She finds that there are five girls ranging in age from 14 to 17. They are all at least 4 months pregnant, and all plan to keep their babies. They've volunteered to be in the group because of conflicts at home and a desire for information. The leader also discovers that their needs range from dealing with their peers, handling guilt associated with religious beliefs, needing nutrition information, parenting skills, coping with pregnancy, planning for the baby, and needing information regarding the effects of drugs, alcohol, and smoking on the fetus.

Given these needs, an education and support group would be beneficial to educate the girls on various aspects of pregnancy, as well as to facilitate personal sharing in an effort to establish support among members.

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During the first session of any group, the leader needs to clarify the purpose with the members. By doing this, the leader ensures that the purpose is clear and hopefully coincides with what the members want or expect. Sometimes it is the leader who determines exactly what is to happen in the group. This is true for such groups as DUI or certain task groups. Other times it is the members who have much to say about the purpose. No matter who is determining the purpose, the important point is that the purpose is clarified during the first session.

Common Questions About Purpose

Certain questions often arise regarding the purpose of groups. Although some of them may seem similar, each one addresses slightly different issues.

Can the Group Have More Than One Purpose?

Yes. Many groups may have multiple purposes, such as providing support, information, and therapy. The pairing of values clarification with counseling or drug information is compatible and can set the stage for an effective and interesting group experience. For example, a group for people just released from an in-patient psychiatric treatment center could have at least two purposes: to provide support and to provide information on such subjects as budgeting and how to interview for a job. A group for teenagers who are in gangs could also have multiple purposes—conflict mediation, counseling, and providing information about alternatives to gangs.

EXAMPLE

The group consists of six teens in an alternative school. The purpose is to help them improve their attitude about school, to focus on problems at home, and to help them get along better with others.

SCOTT: I didn't do any schoolwork for the last week.

LEADER: Is there a reason for that?

SCOTT: I think algebra is hard and I don't like to read.

ERIC: I did what we said about doing the work even if I didn't like it and then rewarded myself by playing some video games.

LEADER: What are others of you doing in regard to studying?

DENNIS: I get real frustrated when doing those stupid math problems.

LEADER: I have a better idea. Instead of talking about studying, let's talk today about something that applies to school and to life in general. It is called *low frustration tolerance*....

In this example the leader shifts from more of an educational purpose to a counseling purpose in teaching low frustration tolerance from REBT theory.

Sometimes leaders mix purposes in incompatible ways. For example, an unskilled leader in a group on child rearing might mistakenly use 30 minutes of the group's time to do counseling with a woman complaining about her husband. Ideally, the leader would meet with the woman at the end of the session or the next day, but not during the group because the other members have come for a totally different purpose. In residential settings such as halfway houses, juvenile centers, or prisons, incompatible purposes often emerge. In these settings, leaders sometimes try to deal in a single session with issues such as problems with parents, tensions between residents, house rules, and disciplinary procedures. The issues should be separated into two or three different meetings, because each has a tone and agenda that does not really mesh with the others.

The first session of any group is another example of a multiple-purpose group session. The leader always has at least two purposes in mind. One is

introducing the general content of the group (such as study habits, communication skills, increasing marital happiness), and the other is getting members clear about the group and how it will be conducted.

EXAMPLES

It is the first session of a cancer support group. The leader has two purposes—one is to help members get comfortable being in the group. The other is to encourage members to share their thoughts and feelings about their illness and to provide valuable information and support for each other.

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It is the first session of a high school group for gay, lesbian, and transgendered students. Given the sensitive nature of this group, the primary purpose is to get members to feel comfortable being in the group, especially if the members are not familiar with each other. The other purpose is to introduce some of the difficult issues that will be discussed in subsequent sessions.

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It is the first session bringing two gangs together to resolve their differences. The leader's primary purpose is to make sure things do not heat up and that a positive tone is set. The leader also wants members to begin a dialog about how they can coexist with each other and to break down the rigid boundaries that each gang has set for itself.

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There are also multiple purposes for the final session: covering content relevant to the group and spending time helping members gain closure since the group is ending.

EXAMPLES

It is the last of six sessions of a group at a women's shelter. The leader has three purposes—one is to deal with any unfinished business or issues that are still not resolved. The second purpose is to help members reinforce what they learned and share hope and encouragement with each other. The third purpose is to have members say goodbye to the other members, have members feel they are not alone, and encourage contact with each other for support.

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Because it is the end of the school year, it is the last session of a group for teenage loners. One purpose is to try to get members to commit to connecting with people over the summer. The leader would most likely focus on each person's

plan to be with other people for the summer. The other purpose is to say goodbye and share what they have learned from the group.

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The main thing to consider when developing multiple purposes is whether or not they are compatible.

Must Each Session Have a Purpose?

Yes. A good group leader should have in mind the purpose or purposes of each specific session. So far, our discussion of purpose has mostly centered on the content of the group and the overall purpose. Purpose can be looked at more specifically. One purpose might be to clarify what the rest of the sessions will be like. Other purposes can be to give feedback to each other; to get to know each other better; or to discuss a specific topic such as religion, sex, or the need for approval. Sometimes the leader, the members, or both will decide beforehand what the purpose of the next session will be. The following is a list of possible purposes for a session or a part of a session:

- To have fun
- To be informative
- To build trust
- To increase commitment
- To be thought provoking
- To discuss group process—that is, what is happening between members
- To discuss gender, race, or other cultural issues that exist in the group
- To accomplish a task
- To work on personal issues

Each of these may serve either as part of a multiple purpose or the sole purpose for one or more sessions. For instance, a leader who discovers that the group lacks trust or commitment would probably want to focus part of the next meeting on those issues rather than on the overall purpose, such as personal growth, getting out of prison, living with cancer, or learning assertiveness. Following are some examples of the specific purposes of group sessions.

■ EXAMPLES

This is a growth group consisting of three women and five men. The leader starts the session by saying:

LEADER: Tonight I thought it might be helpful to discuss something that I have observed in the group. Ever since Gloria shared that she is a lesbian, there has been an underlying tension or something, and I think the group could benefit from talking about this.

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In the fifth session of a therapy group, Sandy starts rambling again. The leader decides that the group is far enough along to start giving feedback to one another. He says the following to the group and to Sandy:

LEADER: Sandy, I want to pick up on something that I think will help you and the other members of the group. I want to do a feedback exercise where we tell each other how we experience them in the group. That is, for the next 45 minutes, we are going to give each other feedback. Here's what I'd like you to do.



It is the third session of a support group composed of juveniles in a detention center. The leader notices that there is no energy, even though the group began only 10 minutes ago. She decides, therefore, that the best purpose for this session is to work on commitment and trust and says to the group:

LEADER: On a 1 to 10 scale, with 10 being *a lot* and 1 being *none,* how much commitment do you have to this group?

After the information is gathered, the leader focuses the remainder of the session on why members are not committed and what would increase their commitment.



It is the third in a series of five sessions of an educational group whose overall purpose is to teach nursing supervisors new ways to deal with their staff. The leader starts by saying:

LEADER: Today, we are going to focus on nonverbal behavior. I want to go over some of the latest research, which I found to be quite useful; then I'll ask for reactions and comments. Jefferson and Smith studied the nonverbal behavior of 22 nursing supervisors and found ...



A therapy group in its third session is composed of mental-health patients. The leader opens the group by saying, "Who has something to bring up tonight?" Two of the seven members respond. Joe says he wants to talk about his mom and her desire to control him. Molly mentions her anxiety at work. The leader says to the group:

LEADER: Tonight, we'll focus on Molly's and Joe's concerns, and then during the last hour we'll spend time talking about learning to control our feelings by paying attention to the things that we tell ourselves.



As you can see, a leader can establish the session's purpose in a variety of ways. The simple, direct approach is often a very good way to make the purpose clear.

Can the Purpose Change?

Yes. Groups often start out as education, support, or growth groups; as they develop, the members begin to share on a more personal level. If the leader sees a need to shift to counseling, it is usually valuable for him to discuss this in the group. Perhaps the best way to make the change is for the leader to explain how the group could alter its purpose. If the group decides to switch its emphasis, the leader needs to be aware that it will probably take one or two sessions to completely change the direction. *Often leaders make the mistake of shifting the purpose of the group without informing the members.* As a result, members feel frustrated, confused, fearful, or resentful. As we have said throughout this discussion, it is important that the leader and members remain clear about the group's purpose, and the leader should reiterate the purpose whenever necessary. If the leader decides to shift the purpose, she must be sure that the members are aware of her intent and that they also desire the shift.

■ EXAMPLE

It is the third session of an education and support group for stepfamily living. Four women make up the group. The leader has noticed that all the members have numerous personal concerns that are interfering with effective living.

SHEILA: I can't stand the way their mother treats them. I actually called her up and threatened her. I can't help it!

CELINA: I get so angry when Juan's mom is late all the time in meeting us! But I am just an angry person, or so my husband says. He even told me the other night he could not take my anger much longer.

LEADER: Let me talk about a possible shift here in the group. I know we originally got together because of stepfamily issues, but I have noticed that each of you has some major concerns that aren't necessarily related to stepfamilies. Sheila, you and Celina seem to have some major issues with anger. Dealing with anger seems like a good topic. Another topic could be dealing with guilt because Dana, you and Sharon both mentioned that last week and again this week. Would you like to shift the group to more of a counseling group about these and other issues, still focusing on stepfamily issues as they relate to these?

DANA: I need help in both areas. I don't want to *not* be able to talk about my adjustment in my stepfamily.

LEADER: We will definitely keep talking about stepfamily matters as well, but I just did not want to switch the purpose unless we all agree.

CELINA: I'm for it because I need help or my husband may leave.

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Can There Be No Purpose?

Not having a purpose is inadvisable. Groups without a purpose usually dissolve because of lack of interest and direction. Although you may choose to bring together a group of people having no predetermined goal in mind, the purpose of the first meeting should be to decide what the purpose should be for the remainder of the meetings. In fact, a group with no purpose cannot really be termed a group; rather, it is a social gathering.

If the Leader Is Clear, Will the Members Be?

Not always. Often, members have their own ideas of what the group should be about, and they try to steer it in that direction. In addition, some members will come to groups for reasons other than the stated purpose; that is, they come to complain, to preach, or to attack and will not follow the leader's direction. Another reason members may not be clear about the group's purpose is that some find it hard to understand what is going on. Because of their anxiety, they are not able to listen well. By reiterating, the leader can do much to clarify the intent of the group for the members. If she sees that some of the members are confused, she will probably want to do one of two things: (1) meet with those members who seem confused or (2) discuss the problem in the group. Often, this clears up the confusion.

■ EXAMPLE

The leader views this group as a support group for those with hepatitis C. Two members want the group to be a therapy group and continually bring up unrelated personal problems. It is the second session and the leader realizes that the two members may not understand the purpose.

MARY: I am still trying to decide if I want to take the new drug—I am afraid of the side effects.

TONI: I understand. My doctor wants me to try something new and I am scared to death, but I do not like how I have been feeling lately.

HECTOR: I think we can all be supportive of each other, especially when taking one of those powerful drugs. We could meet more often or at least make sure we are in contact by phone or e-mail.

NICOLE: I know I could use the contact during the holidays. I have such problems with my in-laws. They are the hardest people to buy gifts for. Do any of you worry about buying the right gift?

CHERYL: My problem is being disappointed by the gifts my husband buys me. He always....

Leader: Let me talk about something here. During the first session, we talked a lot about being supportive of each other and how this is a support group. However, it really is not a general support group but rather a specific one focusing on issues pertaining to having hepatitis C. I'd rather have us stay focused on those kinds of issues. Cheryl and Nicole, I realize you have concerns that are important to you, and if you would like to talk about those privately with me, that would be fine. Let's go back to what Mary, Toni, and Hector were talking about.

If the two members continue to be unclear as to the purpose of the group, the leader would want to talk with them privately. After talking with them, if they continue to bring up unrelated therapy issues, the leader may decide to ask them not to be in the group and find them a therapy situation that fits their needs—either another group or individual counseling.

Purpose in Single-Session Groups

Most of our comments have implied that groups meet for a number of sessions. Many groups meet only once. When leading a single-session group, clarity of purpose is even more essential. The leader needs to be very clear about why this group is meeting and then plan a group that will accomplish the desired objective in the time allotted. The group's purpose may be to discuss and determine a treatment plan for a patient, to resolve a conflict, or to plan an event. Being clear will help the leader use the time effectively and accomplish the desired outcomes. Often at single-session group meetings, little is accomplished because the members keep switching topics and the leader fails to keep the discussion within the boundaries of the purpose. Members may also focus for half the meeting on something that is irrelevant, thus necessitating a second meeting. A good leader should be clear as to the purpose, what needs to be done, and how much time should be spent on introductions, warm-up, background information, and the various topics.

Evaluation of Group Success

Regardless of the purpose of your group, it is important to determine if the purpose has been achieved and to what extent. Although a leader may have a clear idea in his or her mind as to the purpose, only some form of evaluation will confirm the extent to which the purpose has been accomplished. Measuring outcomes allows for the leader to adjust aspects of both content and process to better reach the intent of the group experience. Although group leaders should not become preoccupied with evaluating their groups, periodic evaluation can give them useful feedback about their ostensible purpose, as well as information on the kinds of experiences that are most helpful in meeting the goals of their

members. For a thorough discussion regarding evaluating groups, see Riva and Lange's (2014) short book, *How Leaders Can Assess Group Counseling*.

Three kinds of evaluations are possible: (1) evaluation of the changes that actually occur in members' lives, (2) self-evaluation by the group leader, and (3) evaluation by the members. There are advantages and limitations to each, and each type of evaluation serves a particular function.

Evaluation of the Changes in Members' Lives

Perhaps the most important type of evaluation is the evaluation of how the group experience has impacted the members' behavior. Do students get better grades in school or have fewer reported incidents of misbehavior? Do spouses communicate more effectively? Do teen mothers provide better care for their babies than they would have if they had not been in the group? Do unemployed workers from the group get jobs sooner than those not in the group? Do members who experience much guilt and anxiety cope with life better after being in the group? Some of these questions are rather easy to answer and some are difficult to answer, but there is an increasing demand for evidence-based evaluation. Agencies, schools, and institutions want to see data showing that the group work is effective in bringing about changes.

Some groups easily lend themselves to outcome-based evaluation, whereas with others, it may be difficult to quantify changes in members. Members' self-reports are one method of determining if they are actually changing. Throughout the life of the group, the leader should ask members to comment on changes they are making. Of course, such responses are subjective and not always accurate, but the leader can often get some idea of the impact the group is having on the members. Another method of evaluating behavioral change is to have other people in the members' lives give a more objective evaluation. These outside evaluators may be teachers, employers, parents, spouses, friends, probation officers, primary care medical treatment staff, or individual therapists. In a school setting, the leader may receive informal comments or anecdotes, such as, "Yes, Billy is definitely paying more attention in class," or more formal feedback through the use of a written behavioral checklist. Presuming that Billy's behavior in class had a negative impact on his academic work, checking Billy's grades at the end of the next full marking period may be a way to evaluate the impact of the group. Other objective data school counselors can review to determine the group's success might be referrals for discipline issues for former group members or school attendance records.

To produce data measuring the outcome, the leader must follow a procedure that includes these steps:

1. Determine the outcome goals of the specific group; for example, students stay in school, students reduce the number of days of skipping school, grades increase, members stop smoking, members have fewer panic attacks, members get jobs. For some groups, the leader, may need to determine goals for each member.

2. Collect pre-group data. Examples would be the number of panic attacks, number of days skipped, number of fights at work, number of work days missed.
3. Focus the group sessions on the desired outcome goals. Allow members to work on their goals.
4. Develop an appropriate form for members to complete regarding their progress toward the established goals. It is very important for the form to contain questions that allow measurement of the outcome of the group.
5. Determine whether people other than the members can be involved in evaluating outcome and, if so, obtain permission from the members and contact those people.
6. Collect data periodically, using a form.
7. At the end of the group, collect data, using a form.
8. Plan for follow-up data collection by either mailing forms to the members (and others if appropriate) at certain intervals or giving members extra forms and asking them to send the completed forms at designated intervals. Collecting data at 3 months after the group ends, then 6 months, and then 1 year is an excellent way to evaluate the group based on lasting changes in the members.

The Leader's Self-Evaluation

Many leaders do a self-evaluation after each session. Usually a self-evaluation is simple and straightforward. The leader will want to recall any interactions or dynamics that seemed especially important and evaluate her role in the group. For example, "My instructions for doing the 'Family Sculpture' exercise were confusing" or "I could have cut off Dan earlier and kept the group from getting so restless" or "Sarah attacked Bill and I didn't do anything about it." The leader can ask herself these questions:

- How closely did I follow my plan?
- When I deviated from my plan, was it because I thought of a more appropriate strategy at the moment or because I felt lost or overwhelmed by the group?
- How closely was I able to meet the needs of the individual members?
- Did things happen in the group that I did not plan for or anticipate?
- Could I have predicted these with more forethought?
- What have I learned from the session that I can implement next time?
- On a 1–10 scale, how would I rate my overall satisfaction with the session? What can I do to improve the rating?

The leader should keep these self-evaluations and periodically review them to observe the progress that he is making. If there are areas where the leader feels

he is not improving, he may wish to give them special attention or ask a fellow group leader or supervisor for help.

The Members' Evaluations

The leader will find it helpful to have members evaluate the group. An informal evaluation can be done as part of the closing of any session. The leader might say: "What happened in the group during this session that was particularly valuable for you?" A more formal evaluation can be done a third of the way or halfway through the group. This might involve a check sheet with questions about the process that takes place in the group, as well as its content, and ways in which the group has been helpful. A final written evaluation is also helpful for the leader in planning future groups. A useful evaluation form for the end of groups could contain the following questions, plus some additional ones that are specific to the given group.

- What were the most important things you gained from being in this group?
- What activities, discussions, or topics stood out for you?
- What did you like most about the group?
- What did you like least about the group?
- What would have made the group better for you?
- What could the leader have done differently that would have made the group better for you?

A leader should exercise caution when reading member evaluations. Some members may not like her and thus give inaccurate feedback, or members may have a need to please and therefore give only positive feedback. Some members give dishonest feedback because they feel threatened by or concerned for the leader. For example, if the leader continually asks members if they like the group or if it is being helpful to them, members may conclude that the leader is fishing for positive feedback and may be reluctant to offer constructive criticism. Some members develop what can be termed a "groupie" mentality; they identify so strongly with the power of the leader that, no matter what happens in the group, they believe it is for the good of the group. Because it is natural to look for positive feedback, such feedback may lull leaders into thinking that their groups are terrific, when in fact there are problems that should be corrected. We cannot sufficiently stress the benefit of evaluating your groups. Much can be learned from evaluations, using any of the preceding methods of evaluation. The ultimate evaluation may lie in experimental research, with experimental and control groups. Research of this nature is difficult to design because accurate assessment of outcomes is not easy.

Concluding Comments

Being clear about the purpose is the most important factor in determining the outcome of a group. It also affects the leader's choice of the kind of group, membership, topics, dynamics, and depth as well as the leader's role. Clarity of purpose is crucial no matter what type of group is being led. The purpose of the group serves as the map for guiding the leader in planning and conducting the session. Many beginning leaders fail to be clear as to the purpose, or they do not stick to the purpose. Sessions have different purposes, sometimes more than one. Also, the purpose of the group can change as the group develops.

Evaluation of groups can be accomplished in a variety of ways. Ideally leaders will evaluate themselves and have members evaluate themselves and their experience as a group member.

ACTIVITIES

1. Think about any current groups you are leading or of which you are a member. Is the purpose clear? If so, why? If the purpose is not clear, why? How can you change this situation?
2. Think of three different group situations where the purpose was not clear either due to the members or leader. (If you have not had much group counseling experience, think of classes, family situations, study groups, church groups, or school groups.)
   a. What was the consequence of the confused purpose?
   b. What could the leader have done to improve the group?
3. Discuss with classmates or colleagues why clarity of purpose is so important for groups and staff meetings. (We believe that by discussing this you will have a much greater chance of remembering that this is the most important aspect of group leading. Without clarity of purpose, a group has a good chance of going poorly.)



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. View again videos 3.1 and 3.2.
   a. What do you see as the difference?
   b. What did the leader do in video 3.2 to make sure the group stayed with the purpose?
   c. What would have happened if the leader had not had clarity of purpose?

2. View video 3.3.
   a. What would have happened if the leader had not had clarity of purpose in this video?
   b. Would the teachers have talked about teaching or would they have been talking about the hospital and about the member's mom's medical condition?
3. Review the first two videos—"The Leader Without Skills" (1.1) and "The Leader with Skills" (1.2)—and note the difference regarding clarity of purpose. What skills did the leader in the second group use to clarify the purpose?